



In doing so, Vinesh showed the kind of courage almost uniformly lacking in most sportspersons in India. Most of them, as the saying goes, "crawl when asked to bend." Vinesh's spine has been ramrod straight. She had the courage to take on the system without caring about the consequences. She displayed it even though it cost her what she loved the most — the chance to wrestle.

Only when her protest was forced off the streets and entered the court did Vinesh finally get a chance to compete.

She had been dismissed as a '*khota sikka*' (worthless coin) by Brij

Bhushan. His mockery only strengthened her resolve. It acted as bellows to a fire that always glowed inside her but now burned white hot. Her motivation for the Olympics was as straightforward as they come. She would win a medal just to see the look on the faces of all those who criticised her. She did nearly all that she needed to do. She did something no one ever thought was possible.

Vinesh beat someone who was considered unbeatable. She made her way into a territory no Indian woman had gone before. Her career might not have ended with the grandstand finish she truly deserved,

Showing spine: Months before her flight to Paris, Vinesh led a protest alongside fellow wrestlers, Bajrang Punia and Sakshi Malik, against Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh, the former president of the Wrestling Federation of India (WFI), who faced accusations of sexual harassment. AFP

and she may well return to the sport and win a few more medals.

Regardless of her choice, we are all richer for having experienced Vinesh Phogat as long as we did. There weren't many like her, and there won't be many like her.